

✦ THE SOUL SPACE ✦

The First Seven Nights™

By Sonali Badani

Ten minutes a night. Seven nights.
Nothing your husband needs to know about.

THIS PRACTICE BELONGS TO

name

BONUS THREE · READ THIS ONCE

Read This Once Before You Start

This is the smallest honest way to begin. It is built for a woman who has very little time left at the end of the day and even less energy, which is most of the women I work with, and probably you.

IT IS TEN MINUTES, AND TEN MINUTES MEANS TEN

Set a timer. When it goes, stop, even if you were in the middle of something. Seven days of a thing you actually finish will change more than two days of a thing that ate your evening and then got abandoned.

WRITE IT BY HAND

You saw what happened in the masterclass when the room wrote instead of typed. Keep one notebook for this and do not use it for anything else.

YOU ARE GOING TO MISS A NIGHT

Almost everybody does, usually night four or five, and usually because of a child or a fever or a family function. Missing a night is part of the plan, not a failure of it. Pick it up the next evening at the night you left. Do not go back to night one and do not do two in one sitting.

DO NOT TELL HIM YET

Not because it is a secret. Because when you announce something like this on day one, you hand him a way to measure it, and you hand yourself a reason to perform it. Let the first week be quietly yours. If he notices something on his own around day nine or ten, that is worth more than anything you could have told him.

YOU ARE NOT TRYING TO FIX ANYTHING THIS WEEK

Nothing in these seven nights asks you to improve your marriage. The only job this week is to see it clearly. Every woman I have worked with tried to fix it before she could see it, and that is the reason so many of them ended up believing the problem was them.

If your situation involves violence, threats, or being controlled, this is not the right place to start, and none of this comes first. Your safety does. In India you can call 181, the women's helpline, at any hour.

✦ THE SEVEN NIGHTS

**Ten minutes.
Same time each night.
A pen, and one notebook.**

You are not trying to fix anything this week. You are learning to see it.

THE FIRST SEVEN NIGHTS™

Sonali Badani · The Soul Space

NIGHT 1 · TEN MINUTES

See one thing

TONIGHT

Tonight you are only looking. Not changing anything, not saying anything differently, not being better than you were yesterday.

Somewhere in today there was a moment when something tightened. It might have been a sentence, a tone, a silence, a look, a phone picked up at the wrong second. It probably lasted three seconds and you moved straight past it, because you have moved past it a thousand times.

That is the moment. Go back and find one.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Two minutes.** Sit still and walk through the day from morning until now. Do not skip the boring parts, that is usually where it is hiding.
2. **Five minutes.** Find one moment where something in you tightened. Write down what happened in six words or fewer. Only what happened. Not what it meant, not what it always means, and not what he should have done.
3. **Three minutes.** Read your six words back. Notice how small the actual event is compared to how it felt.

TONIGHT'S SIX WORDS

Write freely

If you cannot find one, that is a real answer too. Write, today I did not notice one, and do night one again tomorrow. Most women find three the second time they look.

NIGHT 2 · TEN MINUTES

Name what you did

TONIGHT

Last night you found the moment. Tonight you find what you did with it.

Everybody has a pattern here, and it is remarkably consistent. It runs the same way whether the argument is about money, his mother, the children, or nothing at all. Going quiet and waiting to be noticed. Explaining yourself one more time and then another. Getting suddenly, sharply busy. Bringing up something from four years ago. Becoming very calm and very cold.

You already know yours. You have just never written it down in a sentence that is honest enough to be uncomfortable.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Two minutes.** Read yesterday's six words again.
2. **Five minutes.** Write what you did next. Be specific and be honest. Nobody is reading this. A vague answer here will cost you the whole week.
3. **Three minutes.** Ask yourself one question. How old is this reaction? Most women find it is considerably older than the marriage.

WHAT I DID NEXT

Write freely

If what you wrote makes you wince a little, you did it correctly. If it reads like a description of a reasonable woman behaving reasonably, go back and write the version you would not want anybody to read.

NIGHT 3 · TEN MINUTES

Find the three seconds

TONIGHT

There is a gap between the thing that happens and the thing you do. It is very short, and right now it is closed, which is why the reaction feels automatic. It is not automatic. It is fast.

Tonight you are going to prove to yourself that the gap exists, by finding it after the fact.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Two minutes.** Take today's moment, or yesterday's if today was quiet.
2. **Five minutes.** Write down what was happening in your body in the second before you reacted. Chest, jaw, stomach, shoulders, hands, breath. Something changed first. It always does.
3. **Three minutes.** Give it a name you would recognise anywhere. The tight chest. The hot face. The going flat. That name is your early warning, and from tomorrow it is what you are listening for.

WHAT HAPPENS IN MY BODY FIRST

Write freely

If you felt nothing at all, that is common and it is not a problem. It usually means the reaction has been running for a long time. Try the same exercise on a moment from last week that still stings. The body remembers that one.

NIGHT 4 · TEN MINUTES

One sentence, said differently

TONIGHT

Tonight is the first night you actually do something, and it is going to be much smaller than you want it to be.

One sentence. Not a conversation, not an explanation of what you learned, not a plan for the two of you. One sentence, said once, in an ordinary moment, without any weight attached to it.

Something like, I have had a long day. Or, I would like ten minutes with you. Or, that was hard for me. Say it flat, say it once, and then stop talking. The stopping is the exercise.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Two minutes.** Decide the sentence before you say it, and write it down first.
2. **Five minutes.** Find a normal moment and say it. Not after an argument. Not while he is on a call. An ordinary moment.
3. **Three minutes.** Come back and write what happened, including if nothing happened.

THE SENTENCE, AND WHAT HAPPENED AFTER

Write freely

There is a good chance he says nothing much, or says something that lands wrong. That does not mean it failed. You are not measuring his reply this week. You are measuring whether you could say one true thing without going into your pattern afterwards.

NIGHT 5 · TEN MINUTES

Let his quiet be his

TONIGHT

Tonight is about the silence, because for most women this is the single biggest one.

When he goes quiet, something in you decides very quickly what it means, and then you respond to the meaning rather than to the silence. You chase, or you go colder than he is. Both of those are reactions to a story, and the story arrived in under a second without asking your permission.

His quiet is allowed to be about his day, his work, his father, his own head, and nothing at all to do with you.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Two minutes.** Write down what you usually decide his silence means.
2. **Five minutes.** Write three other things it could equally have meant today. Ordinary, boring ones. He is tired. He is thinking about a payment. He had a bad call.
3. **Three minutes.** Read the four options back. Notice that you picked the first one automatically, and notice that you had no evidence for it.

WHAT I DECIDE IT MEANS, AND THREE OTHER THINGS IT COULD MEAN

Write freely

This one is uncomfortable for a lot of women, because the story is usually old and it is usually about being unwanted. If it stings, write that down too. It is the most useful line in the week.

NIGHT 6 · TEN MINUTES

One small repair

TONIGHT

Not a big conversation. Nothing that begins with, we need to talk.

A repair is a small gesture that says the connection matters more than the point I was making. It takes four seconds and it does not require an apology, a resolution, or agreement about who was right.

A hand on his shoulder while walking past. Making the tea without being asked. Saying, that came out sharper than I meant. Sitting next to him instead of across from him. That is the size we are working at.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Two minutes.** Pick one repair. Small enough that you could do it without thinking about it for an hour first.
2. **Five minutes.** Do it. Then leave it alone. Do not follow it with an explanation of what you just did or why.
3. **Three minutes.** Write what it cost you to do it, because that number is interesting.

THE REPAIR, AND WHAT IT COST ME

Write freely

If you could not bring yourself to do it, write why. That reason is usually the most honest sentence anybody writes in the seven nights, and it is almost always some version of, I did not want to be the one who goes first again.

NIGHT 7 · TEN MINUTES

Read the week back

TONIGHT

Sit with all six pages open in front of you. This is the only night where you do not write anything new for the first half.

Read them in order, slowly. What you are looking for is not the six separate events. It is the one thing running underneath all of them, wearing six different sets of clothes.

THE TEN MINUTES

1. **Four minutes.** Read nights one to six. Do not skim your own handwriting.
2. **Three minutes.** Write the pattern in one sentence, in your own words, the way you would say it out loud to somebody you trust.
3. **Three minutes.** Take out your Marriage Pattern Score sheet and re-score statement three and statement eight only. Write today's date next to them.

MY PATTERN, IN ONE SENTENCE

Write freely

A drop of one point on either statement after a single week is real. Do not talk yourself out of it and do not wait until it is a drop of twenty before you allow it to count.

BONUS THREE · WHAT COMES NEXT

What Happens On Night Eight

You now know something about yourself that you did not know eight days ago, and knowing it is genuinely worth something. Please do not let anybody tell you a week of honest attention was nothing.

Here is the part I would rather tell you straight.

Week two is where almost everybody stops. Not because they lose interest, and not because it stopped working. It stops because seeing the pattern and being able to interrupt it in a real moment are two completely different skills, and the second one is much harder than the first.

Around day nine or ten there is usually one evening where you see the whole thing happening, in real time, with total clarity, and you do the automatic thing anyway. That evening is the one that makes women quietly decide it must just be them. It is not. It is the point where a pattern that has been running for fifteen or twenty years pushes back, and it is the exact point where doing this alone stops being reasonable.

That is what the next twenty one days are for, and it is the reason they are not designed to be done by yourself.

Inside The Rewired Love Method, the twenty one day practice picks up exactly where night seven leaves off, with a weekly call for the Thursday you react the way you always have and need somewhere to bring it, and a group where somebody notices when you go quiet.

And if you never join anything of mine, do this. Keep the notebook. Keep the Trigger Card up. Re-score yourself on the same date next month. That alone will show you more about your marriage than another year of waiting for it to get better on its own.